

Lesson Plan: Children's Online Media Literacy

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MLIS 4015: User and Access Services

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May 14, 2024

Topic: Children's Online Media Literacy

Audience: The target learner of this lesson is Upper Elementary students, fourth and fifth graders. The setting is a school library and would best be integrated and co-taught alongside a research assignment. This lesson will introduce the students to utilizing media resources for their assignment. It is geared toward media and internet research and literacy.

Time: The length of this lesson will be one hour, ideally during regular library class.

Format: This class is intended to be in-person with a class size of up to 24 students.

Layout / Needs: Technology needs are one computer with an internet connection per student and an overhead projector that all students can see for the librarian teacher computer. Layout should consist of computers set up on clustered tables where students can interact in smaller groups.

Two copies of the Digital Research Organizer worksheet per student will be needed as well.

Pedagogical Approach: The pedagogical approach is guided discussion to facilitate repetitive active learning. Students this age are usually eager to use a computer but possibly less interested in research, so keeping the class engaged through guided discussion will keep them interested.

This lesson will best to be co-taught with a subject teacher for a current research assignment, allowing the student to actively use their new knowledge right away for that assignment.

Primary challenges/risks: One challenge with students in this age group is that small group discussions can become chaotic and veer off-topic quickly. Cutting this portion short might be helpful if the students get too rambunctious. Another similar challenge is if the group is low energy, and either isn't participating in the discussion or loses interest partway through the lesson. Since the lesson is designed around letting the students lead the discussion, if they are not engaging, it may be wise to prepare portions of the lesson that is designed for the students to fill in.

Lesson Objectives

At the end of this class, students will learn how to find media resources, classify and compare them, and identify if they are reliable. They will utilize these research methods for a class assignment.

Introduction

The students likely already know you, but if not, you can introduce yourself, as well as the topic of this lesson. (1 min)

Formulating the Research Question

Ask the students how much independent research they have done for personal interest or school assignments. This will give a sense of how much they already know about internet and media searches and sources. While you may already have this information, as previously coordinated with their subject teacher, ask them if they have any current research assignments. Ask the class for suggestions for ideas to research together during this lesson. These can be for fun and what the students are personally interested in (Pokemon, a TV show, etc). (5 min)

Deciding where to start the search

Ask the class; “Where do you think the best place to look for the answer to our suggested research topic would be?” Discuss options, including online databases and resources inside and outside the library. While this lesson isn’t about databases, it is helpful to remind them that online media is not the only place to find information. Engage in a class discussion about what sources might be more useful to answer what kind of questions. Continue discussing deeper, touching on sources such as online media, Wikipedia, reputable news sources (and how to tell what is reputable), non-reputable sources, journals, etc. (6 min)

Identify reliable sources

Use the overhead projector so that the entire class can see and start a search of a student suggested topics. Ask the class some of these questions as you search.

What type of source is this?

Which is a reliable source?

Which isn't?

Let them guide your search on the overhead, instructing on best choices as needed. Emphasize the importance of looking at quotation marks, reference markers, etc. As a class, analyze several specific sources, pointing out important ways to differentiate source types. While looking at these sources, fill out a Digital Research Organizer on the overhead projector. Discuss as a class and compare how the sources are different, identifying where the source of the research came from and how to determine if it is reliable or not. (10 min)

Active Learning

Hand out the Digital Research Organizer and have the students break into groups (ideally 4 – 5 groups of 5 or 6 kids), each choosing one of the research questions proposed earlier in the lesson. One student will need to volunteer to use the computer with the others gathered around, while another student is responsible for taking notes on what the group is discussing. Instruct them to search for sources on a student suggested topic and put their findings on the worksheet, the same way modeled on the projector earlier. The worksheet will ask them to list three sources they looked at, what type of source it was, how useful and reliable they think the source will be for their research, and why. (12 min)

Evaluating the results

Invite the class to return to their desks and let each group briefly share back their search and results. Sample questions to ask for their feedback:

Were they successful?

How do they know they were successful?

How did they differentiate what sources they picked?

Did they have trouble identifying reliable sources?

Did this activity spark further insights on where they might find better results? (12 min)

Individual Research

Instruct each student to start research on their topic (per their class research assignment) with a new Digital Research Organizer worksheet. They can utilize best practices just learned from the group work and discussion to implement into their personal search. Let them know you are available to answer questions during this quiet time at the end of class. Remind the students not to use the computers for anything other than this research topic, and not to get distracted by games or YouTube. Open the room for any questions before class is dismissed. Students should turn in both personal and group worksheets before dismissal. (12 min)

Assessment

Use the individual Digital Research Graphic worksheet to assess if the students understood the lesson. Their answers on the worksheet will demonstrate if they can identify the type of sources they found, compare them, and if that source will be useful. The worksheet answers will also determine if they are able to identify reliable media sources for their research topic. Send the individual worksheet back to the subject teacher for them to hand back to their students. The students will utilize the worksheet to continue their research assignment. Comparing the group worksheet and the individual worksheet may give you additional insight into if the students strengthened their learning outcomes through the class.

Considerations

One consideration with this lesson is that it should be taught after students already have database or keyword knowledge. This lesson will specifically focus on online media and without some prior experience with database or keyword searches, it may be more difficult to implement this lesson plan in the time allotted. If they do not have that prior knowledge, students might need more direction on keyword searches than on which sources to choose.

Another consideration is working with the subject teacher on co-teaching this lesson plan. It is best to meet with this teacher prior to teaching this lesson to ensure the lesson plan can be integrated in the most synergistic way with the class research assignment. Planning together will also ensure that the lesson aligns with the timing of their assignment, and they can use the skills they learn right away as they continue researching. It would also be useful for the students to already have the topic chosen for their assignment so their individual research for their worksheet will be utilized for their assignment.

Conclusion

This lesson is designed to break down the task of researching from a large group into smaller and smaller groups. It starts with guidance for the whole class, then small groups, then individual. This will help students build confidence and experience to start research on their own, going through the process three times during the lesson. Breaking into small research groups will engage them in active learning; they can brainstorm with other students, learn from and build on each other's ideas. The large group discussions and share backs at each interval keep the students engaged and continue bringing new insights into the lesson, all returning to their understanding of the stated lesson objective.

It is important that each student have access to their own computer, as this additional hands-on experience with their worksheet adds solidly to another active learning session. The worksheet is designed to focus their brainstorming on the objective of the lesson and enables them to start their assignment with the best focus on their research. The individual worksheet is used both as a tool within the lesson but also an assessment tool to confirm they have understood the lesson. It is also helpful for the co-teacher whose students can utilize this lesson for their ongoing research assignment.